

Hey, friends. It is Eric Malzone, and this is the first of a handful of audio lectures that we're going to be peppering into this course. And I'm really excited to talk to you about how to connect with your listeners.

So that's the goal. We want to connect with our listeners in an engaging and meaningful way. Whether you're just starting your podcast and you haven't launched your first episode or you've been doing this for a while and you've got hundreds underneath your belt, it's always a good idea to create space and time to engage and connect with your listeners.

Now, these little lectures are going to be a little bit more off the cuff, a little bit more anecdotal. You're definitely going to hear me screw up a few times. But that's part of the podcasting experience and that's OK.

So let's talk about conducting listener surveys. Admittedly, podcasting is really equal parts arts and science. And I feel like the surveying is a little bit on the science side, but there's an art to it, too. So how do we do that, and why is it important?

Now, as I'm actually talking about this, I realize I haven't done one for a while, so it's a little hypocritical. So I'm going to get one done in the next month and post it up. But the actual survey itself, you can do it in so many different ways. You can use Google Forms, Survey Monkey, I believe, is another platform. There's a bunch of them now.

Where do you host it? I host it on my website. So it would be futurefitness.co/survey. But you can also do it on your social media platform with just a link, and direct people there during the audio pieces.

So what goes into a survey? Well, there's the basics. You want to find out their age, their location, their occupation, the demographic information, listening habits.

How often do they listen to your podcast? How often do they listen to podcasts in general? Which platforms are they on? Is that Apple, is it Spotify, is it Google? Whatever it may be, trying to find out some information about how they engage with podcasts overall, not just yours.

Topics of interest-- so which ones do they want to hear? Which ones do they not want to hear? What do they want to hear more of? Give some general ideas and guidelines for them, but also leave a little of that open-ended.

Engagement-- so I'm particularly thinking about how do we actually start conversations with our listeners? And social media is probably one of the best ways. So find out which social media platforms are they on, how often do they use them, things like that. Do they follow you or your podcast on those platforms? Are they interested in things like webinars or live interviews where you can actually have the open feedback loop?

Community building is another category I would tag on. Would they be interested in joining an online community, something like Facebook? Would they be interested in joining in-person events, Masterminds, things like that?

And then, of course, the big question is, how likely are they to recommend the podcast to their friends? Now, you're going to get some interesting responses. I would just rate it 1 to 10.

But also mark people who give you exceptionally good answers. Maybe people will give you subpar answers, reach out to them individually and see if they're open to a conversation because you'd love to hear their feedback. I find that when you get a bad rating, it's actually an opportunity to create a very meaningful relationship, so food for thought.

How would they rate the overall quality of the content? So that goes specifically into categories like the actual audio quality, video quality. The relevance to your overall mission, or to the content that they want to see, the length and duration. All of those things go into the actual quality of the content.

This is also a great opportunity for business development. So what I mean by that is maybe ask these people what kind of paid offerings would they be interested in? Things like courses, subscriptions, one-on coaching, group coaching, things of that ilk. What brands or products related to fitness and wellness do they use and trust? This is a great one to actually start to research what kind of partnerships, brand partnerships, sponsorships, affiliate partnerships do I want to strategically engage in?

It also provides really good fodder for when you reach out to these brands. Because you can actively say, hey, a bunch of my listeners said they specifically love your product. Let's have a chat. It's as simple as that, but it provides a lot of really, really good insights into what type of sponsors and partners will actually be successful in your podcast.

And then there's the open-ended questions. If you've been in the fitness and wellness industry as a coach or a professional, you probably have gotten pretty good at opening questions and I don't have to sit here and convince you of the value of them. But here are some basic ones I would consider.

What are some specific examples of how the podcast has impacted your life-- the listener, that is. Do you have any suggestions for future episodes or formats? Is there anything else you would like to share about your experiences with x, y, z podcast? And then the final one, how can I be a better host?

So that's a survey, general ideas. Google it. Look at other surveys.

Be very creative. Be funny. Use your personality. There's a lot of different ways to do surveys, but they're super valuable and I can't encourage you enough to do them.

Next thing we'll talk about is social engagement and social listening. So social media is a part of our lives, whether we like it or not. I don't have to tell you that.

But finding where you get the most bang for your buck is really important. We can't be everywhere at once. So pick the platforms for your type of engagement, your type of audience that works best-- whether it's Facebook, or Instagram, LinkedIn or X.

I prefer LinkedIn. I have a B2B podcast where I talk about the industry. That seems to be the best place for me. That's where I spend 98% of my social media time.

And it's not just about posting, which is important. You definitely want to post and promote and be a thought leader within the space. But you also have to engage.

So it goes two ways. So you want to be looking for trending topics, looking for trending people, looking for companies, things like that. Just engaging with it, and then being part of the conversation.

So engage with other posts that are relevant to your content niche. It just makes a lot of sense. That way, it gets your name out there in kind of a unique way. You get to share some opinions, maybe get to sharpen your edges against other people's opinions, if you know what I mean.

Also, I like to create and manage polls. LinkedIn has great functionality for that. I had a really engaging poll not too long ago, where I asked people how they would feel if they knew that someone paid to be a guest on a podcast, and that got some really interesting answers. I was highly entertained, but I also got a lot of value out of it. So that's a great way to do things, as well, on social media.

The other thing I would urge you to do is support other podcasters. So I urge you to listen to other people's podcasts. I listen to a ton of podcasts. That's where I pick up a lot of cool tips. It's a way to see the way other people are doing things.

But if you find one that you really liked, share it on social media. Hey, they say that people who listen to podcasts tend to listen to seven or more. So if you find someone who's interested in your podcast, or a podcast that's similar content to yours, post it.

Don't be scared. There's plenty of listeners out there. You can share them all. And it's just a good vibe, as well. And I think once you start supporting other podcasters, they'll start supporting you, and it's a really good way to build your audience.

So that's the big stuff from the tactical side. But also there's the art of the interview, which we're going to dive into much deeper in another audio lecture. But I just want to leave you with one or two major thoughts on that.

I had Sal Di Stefano from Mind Pump on recently, and he said something that really stuck with me. It was that there's just a certain amount of narcissism involved to be a podcast host. I laughed. He laughed. But it's kind of true.

And I think one of the things that may turn off listeners a lot, some of them, is it's not about how smart you are. It's about being an advocate for your audience. So you can assume a certain level of knowledge that your audience has within a specific topic, but don't assume that they know the answers to everything.

Or don't just let your ego drive by saying, of course I know what that means. I know the definition of that. I know periodized programming for x, y, z.

It doesn't have to be that way. Just look at things as if you're going to explain them to a six-year-old. Ask questions as if you're a six-year-old. And just be genuinely curious, and advocating for your audience to get as much information out there as possible. So it's a slight mindset shift, but it's really important, and we'll talk more about it moving forward.

But that's the first audio lecture, connecting with your listeners. Hope you guys enjoyed it. Let me know.